

Red Hat Linux is another Linux success story, a commercial, enterprise-level distro for mainframes. The distro itself came at a fee, but the source code was available for everyone who brought it, allowing a whole range of distros that just rebuilt the code and redistributed. The changes in the rebuild are usually limited to removal of Red Hat trademark logos and graphics, replaced by other logos and graphics. However, Red Hat made considerable profits by giving support to its customers, and charging a fee for upgrades.

Slackware, a great distribution for those who want to jump in at the deep end to start learning Linux, is another distro that adheres to the KISS principle. Slackware is a very simple distro, in the sense that it compromises on user-friendliness by providing an essentially stripped down version of Linux, with a simple desktop environment and no repositories or mechanisms for resolving dependencies. Those who use Slackware will have to start from scratch, which makes it both a great test bed, and a good starting point for those who want to learn the intricacies of Linux. It has a very loyal community, and is the oldest Linux distribution in active development.

Ubuntu changed the OS landscape by offering to ship free CDs to people's homes. Backed by a multi-millionaire by the name of Mark Shuttleworth (who owns a Formula 1 team amongst other things), Ubuntu introduced Linux to a new non-geek audience. Living up to the title of "Linux for Human Beings", Ubuntu was singlehandedly responsible for demystifying what appeared to be a complex OS, and has gathered around it one of the most powerful Linux communities. Support is readily available for a lot of issues, and the distributors themselves offer professional support for a fee. Ubuntu is Debian based, and uses apt-get to resolve dependencies.

After all the considerations, if you still cannot decide which distro to install, we will make a call for you. All said and done, the best distro for home use, for novices, is Linux Mint. This is because it is based on Ubuntu, which makes it easy to start off with, has the added advantage of looking good, and has a large number of software in its repositories. More importantly, it comes with more codecs installed, and consequently, plays more movies and music out of the box than Windows Vista.

The Linux desktop environment

A desktop environment is a fundamental feature to most modern operating system. It is the interface between the user and the oper-